

THE HOLD-UP

ABOUT THE DEALS

You may be either Opener or Responder, but you will always be in the South position.

You are asked to study the Deal and mentally devise a Plan to make the contract.

HOLD-UP LESSON

The hold-up play is one of the first techniques bridge players learn, right up there with finessing. And the first example they are shown will be something like this one.

You are playing a notrump contract.

Your Left Hand Opponent leads the ♥5 and RHO puts on the ♥Q.

Here is the ♥ suit in dummy's and your hands.

Dummy ♥ 8 4

You ♥ A 10 2

Suppose you take your ♥A at the first (or second) trick. Then, whenever you lose a trick to either opponent they will win some ♥ tricks, four of them if LHO has led a 5-card suit.

But suppose you refuse to win your ♥A until the third round; you hold-up. Then, whenever you lose a trick to your RHO he may be void in ♥s because he started out with just three of them. Since he cannot lead a ♥ back to his partner your contract may be successful.

Of course, even after the hold-up, if you lose a later trick to your LHO he will then cash his ♥ tricks. So hold-up plays aren't always perfect solutions.

The Basic Hold-up:

Look at that ♥ suit in a full example.

The contract is 3NT and West's opening lead is the ♥5. East plays ♥Q.

♠ A 7 3
♥ 8 4
♦ K J 10 9 8
♣ 5 4 2

♠ K 8 2
♥ A 10 2
♦ Q 6 3
♣ A K 10 6

Since this is a notrump contract count your winners.

♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 2 : Total = 5.

You need 4 more winners, and Dummy's ♦ suit will provide them.

The danger is that West may hold five ♥s, so when you drive out the ♦A, the defense may be able to win 4 ♥ tricks to go along with their 1 ♦.

So you hold-up your ♥A until the third round. Then you play ♦K and continue with the ♦ suit until the defense takes the ♦A. If it is East who wins, and he started with only 3 ♥s, he will have none to return to his partner's hand. And if East does happen to have a fourth ♥ it means the ♥ suit was originally 4-4 and you will only lose 3 tricks in the suit..

Holding Up with a King

The contract is 3NT and West's opening lead is the ♥Q.
East plays the ♥A and returns the ♥9.

♠ A 7 3
♥ 8 4
♦ K J 10 9 8
♣ Q J 2

♠ K 8 2
♥ K 6 2
♦ Q 6 5 3
♣ A K 5

Since this is a notrump contract count your winners.

♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 3 : Total = 6.

You need 3 more winners, and Dummy's ♦ suit will provide them.
Once East takes the ♥A on the first round the situation becomes identical to the first example.
You hold-up your ♥K until the third round. Then you drive out the ♦A and hope it is East who has it.

Not Holding Up with a King

The contract is 3NT and West's opening lead is the ♥5.
East plays the ♥J.

♠ A 7 3
♥ 8 4
♦ A J 10 9 8
♣ Q J 2

♠ K 8 2
♥ K 6 2
♦ Q 6 5 3
♣ A K 5

Since this is a notrump contract count your winners.

♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 ? : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 3 : Total = 7.

The opening lead guarantees you a ♥ trick.
And you'd better take it right now or East will return a ♥ and West will take all the ♥ winners he happened to be dealt.

This was not a time to hold up, and after you win the first trick you pin all your hopes on the ♦ finesse. If West holds the ♦K you will make the contract. If East holds the ♦K they are going to bury you with ♥s.

Holding Up with A J x: or not:

When your LHO leads a suit in which you hold A J x and RHO plays a high honor, you have an interesting situation. This holding might be just one stopper, but might be two, depending on which defender will be getting the lead.

The contract is 3NT and West's opening lead is the ♠6.
East plays the ♠Q.

♠ 7 3
 ♥ A 8 4 3
 ♦ Q J 10 9
 ♣ K Q 2



♠ A J 2
 ♥ K 6 2
 ♦ A 6 5 3
 ♣ A 7 5

Since this is a notrump contract count your winners.

♠ = 1? : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 3 : Total = 7.

Suppose you hold-up your ♠A until the third round.

You need tricks from ♦s and you must finesse through East. If the finesse fails West will take his ♠ winners.

Suppose you take your ♠A at trick one.

You need tricks from ♦s and you must finesse through East. If the finesse fails West will not be able to lead ♠s without setting up your ♠J.

The contract is 3NT and West's opening lead is the ♠6.
East plays the ♠Q.

♠ 7 3
 ♥ A 8 4 3
 ♦ A 6 5 3
 ♣ K Q 2



♠ A J 2
 ♥ K 6 2
 ♦ Q J 10 9
 ♣ A 7 5

Since this is a notrump contract count your winners.

♠ = 1? : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 3 : Total = 7.

Suppose you take your ♠A at trick one.

You need tricks from ♦s and you must finesse through West. If the finesse fails East will lead a ♠ through your ♠J 2 and West will win a lot of ♠s.

Suppose you hold-up your ♠A until the third round.

You need tricks from ♦s and you must finesse through West. If the finesse fails East will be unable to return a ♠ to his partner (unless they split 4-4).

Holding Up with Two Stoppers:

If you have to establish a suit which is missing two top honors then you may have to hold-up on their suit when you have it double-stopped.

The contract is 3NT and West's opening lead is the ♦J.
East plays the ♦K.

Since this is a notrump contract count your winners.

♠ A 7 3
♥ A 8 3
♦ 6 5 2
♣ J 10 9 6

♠ = 3 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 0 : Total = 7.

You need to get 2 tricks from ♣s. The danger is that West may have a 5-card ♦ suit that can be established before you can set up any ♠ tricks.

Suppose you take your ♦A at trick one and play on ♣s. If the two high ♣s are split, East will win the first ♣ and play another ♦, allowing West to establish the suit. When you again play ♣s, WEST will take his winner and also take some ♦s.

Suppose you allow East to win the ♦K. He will return the suit and drive out one of your stoppers, but he will use his last remaining ♦ to do so. Now, whenever East takes his ♣ winner he will have no ♦s to help West establish the suit. Since West has only one entry in ♣s he can win it and establish the ♦s, but won't be able to get back in to cash them.

♠ K Q 2
♥ K 6 2
♦ A Q 3
♣ Q 7 5 4

Holding Up at a Suit Contract:

The hold-up is utilized most often when you are playing notrump; the purpose usually being to disrupt communications between the defenders by exhausting one defender of his partner's suit. This use of a hold-up doesn't really apply to suit contracts.

There are other reasons for a hold-up, though, which do apply in suit contracts.

The contract is 4♥ and West's opening lead is the ♠3.
East plays the ♠Q.

Since this is a suit contract count your losers.

♠ 8 7
♥ Q 10 8 3
♦ K 7 5
♣ A J 9 4

♠ = 1 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 1 : Total = 4.

You can't avoid losing 1 ♠, and the ♦A is also a sure loser. If the ♣ finesse works you would be home free, but even if it fails you can guarantee the contract with a hold-up play.

The danger is that if East holds the ♦A, West may obtain the lead and play a ♦ through dummy's ♦K, giving you two ♦ losers. You can prevent that from happening if you can prevent West from getting the lead. Since the only suit West can get the lead with is ♠s, all you have to do is let East win the ♠Q and take your ♠A on the second round.

♠ A 6 2
♥ A K J 6 2
♦ 8 6
♣ Q 10 3

Since East cannot attack ♦s from his side he will have to give you the lead. You pull trumps, then finesse the ♣. Even if the finesse loses East cannot play ♦s without setting up dummy's ♦K, so you will eventually get to discard one of your ♦ losers on dummy's fourth ♣.

15 Practice Deals will be worth more than another 1500 words.

Deal 1 Ctr: 3NT Goal: at least ____ winners

Q753

Lead: ♦K

62

A76

QJ984

A964

A83

KQJ5

K10

Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 2 Ctr: 3NT Goal: at least ____ winners

A5

Lead: ♠K

K5

A76

A8653

9843

QJ1073

82

K4

Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 5 Ctr: 3NT Goal: at least ____ winners

A95♣

Lead: ♥6

Q64♦

AQ82♠

753♥

K76♣

A♦

K♦

9♦

J♠

10♠

9♠

4♠

K♥

Q♥

2♥

Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 6 Ctr: 3NT Goal: at least ____ winners

A95♣

Lead: ♥6

A♦

J1094♠

753♥

K76♣

Q♦

6♦

4♦

A♠

Q♠

8♠

2♠

K♥

Q♥

2♥

Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**
Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead:  K

Board: 2
Dealer: **West**
Contract: 3NT
Declarer: East
Lead:  K

Board: 3
Dealer: **North**
Contract: 3NT
Declarer: South
Lead:  3

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**
Contract: 3NT
Declarer: West
Lead:  K

Board: 5
Dealer: **North**
Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead:  6

Board: 6
Dealer: **East**
Contract: 3NT
Declarer: East
Lead:  6

Board 1

North Deals

None Vul

♠ 9 3 2
♥ A 8 7 3
♦ 9 7 4
♣ J 10 2

♠ K Q J 5

♥ K 10

♦ A 8 3

♣ A 9 6 4

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ 10 8 4

♥ 6 5 2

♦ K Q J 10 5

♣ K 8

♠ A 7 6

♥ Q J 9 4

♦ 6 2

♣ Q 7 5 3

West	North	East	South
	1NT	Pass	2♣
Pass	2♠	Pass	2NT
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			
3NT by North			
Lead: ♦ K			

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♦ K, dummy plays the ♦ 2 and West the ♦ 4.

Winners: ♠=4 ♥=0 ♦=1 ♣=1 Total = 6

You need 3 more winners, and they must come from the ♥ suit. The danger is that when you knock out the ♥ A, East may take too many ♦ s. To exhaust West of ♦ s you hold-up your ♦ A until the third round.

East continues with the ♦ Q; dummy plays the ♦ 6 and West the ♦ 7.

East continues with the ♦ J; dummy discards the ♣ 3 and West plays the ♦ 9.

Next you start on ♥ s by playing ♥ K, then overtaking the ♥ 10. Assume that West wins the second ♥.

You were fortunate it was West who took the ♥ A, and that he has no ♦ to return. If he plays a ♥ or a ♠ you will win in dummy. If he plays a ♣ you will jump up with the ♣ A and take your winners, 9 in all.

You were lucky the ♥ A was with West.

But if you had not held-up your ♦ A even good luck wouldn't have helped you.

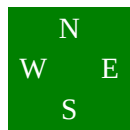
Board 2

West Deals

N-S Vul

♠ A 7 6
 ♥ A 8 6 5 3
 ♦ K 5
 ♣ A K 5

♠ 9 4 3
 ♥ Q 9 7 2
 ♦ A 8 4
 ♣ Q 10 2



♠ 8 2
 ♥ K 4
 ♦ Q J 10 7 3
 ♣ 9 8 4 3

♠ K Q J 10 5
 ♥ J 10
 ♦ 9 6 2
 ♣ J 7 6

West	North	East	South
1 ♥	Pass	1NT	Pass
3NT			
All Pass			
3NT by East			
Lead: ♠ K			

East is to play 3NT. South leads the ♠ K.

North follows with the ♠ 3 and you play the ♠ 2.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=2 ♦=0 ♣=2 Total = 5

Even if ♥s split 3-3 you could only get 2 extra winners there, so it should be clear that you must establish the ♦s. You will have to drive out the ♦ A and hope they don't win too many ♠s at that time. You can help your chances by a hold-up of the ♠ A until the third round.

South continues with the ♠ Q.

North follows with the ♠ 4 and you play the ♠ 8.
South continues with the ♠ J.

North follows with the ♠ 9 and you discard the ♣ 3.

Having just taken the third ♠ trick you now work on ♦s by first playing the ♦ K, then continuing the suit. North wins the third one with his ♦ A. And now the good news - he has no ♠ left to reach his partner's good tricks. So North plays the ♥ Q.

At this point in the play you have three tricks in the bank; ♠ A, ♦ K, ♦ Q. You take your ♥ K, cash the two good ♦s, then lead to dummy for the ♣ A K and ♥ A. Voila!

You were lucky that North had the ♦ A since he only had 3 ♠s.

But what if North actually held 4 ♠s? No problem, in that case the ♠s would have split 4-4 so the defenders could only win 3 ♠ tricks and the ♦ A.

The hold-up lets you make the contract whenever North holds the ♦ A. And if South happened to hold the ♦ A??? You go down.

Board 3

North Deals

None Vul

♠ Q J 7 3 2

♥ 10 7

♦ 6 5

♣ J 10 8 2

♠ 10 5

♥ K 8 5 4

♦ A 10 9 3

♣ K 6 5



♠ K 9 4

♥ A 6 3

♦ Q J 8 2

♣ A Q 4

♠ A 8 6

♥ Q J 9 2

♦ K 7 4

♣ 9 7 3

West	North	East	South
	Pass	Pass	1NT
Pass	2♣	Pass	2♦
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			
3NT by South			
Lead: ♠3			

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♠3. East wins the first trick with the ♠A and returns the ♠8.

West plays the ♠Q and dummy the ♠10.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=3 Total = 7

You can win 3 more ♦ tricks if the finesse works, but even if it doesn't work you can still get the 2 that you need. Of course if East does win the ♦K it would sure be great if he had no ♠ to lead. So you duck the second ♠ and take your ♠K when they play a third round.

West continues with the ♠J; dummy discards a ♥ and East plays the ♠6.

After winning the ♠K you are conveniently in your hand, so you play the ♦Q and let it ride when West plays a low card. Alas, East takes the trick with his ♦K.

It's too bad the finesse didn't work, but it's not too too bad! Because East is out of ♠s and must lead one of the other suits. You don't care which he leads because you can now win 8 more tricks and make your contract.

As long as you were going to finesse into East you could establish the ♦s without allowing West to gain the lead.

And as long as you had held up on the ♠K until the third round you could ensure that East was out of ♠s if he had started with only 3.

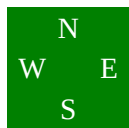
Board 4

West Deals

Both Vul

♠ A K 7 5
 ♥ K J 7
 ♦ A 8 3
 ♣ 9 8 2

♠ 10 8 4
 ♥ 6 5 4 2
 ♦ K Q J 4
 ♣ 7 5



♠ Q 6
 ♥ A 10 9
 ♦ 7 5 2
 ♣ K J 10 6 4

♠ J 9 3 2
 ♥ Q 8 3
 ♦ 10 9 6
 ♣ A Q 3

West	North	East	South
1NT	Pass	3NT	
All Pass			
3NT by West			
Lead: ♦ K			

and South the ♦ 10.

Now start on the ♣s. Play your ♣9 and let it ride. South wins the ♣Q and returns a ♠. Good, he didn't have the fourth ♦.

Win with dummy's ♠Q and force out the ♣A.

The rest of the tricks are yours, nine in all.

If South had only held 2 ♦s it would have been OK to hold up your ♦A just once.

But with this layout you needed to hold up twice.

West is to play 3NT. North leads the ♦K, dummy plays the ♦2 and South the ♦6.

Winners: ♠=3 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=0 Total = 6

You will need some ♣ tricks to make the contract. If North has 5 ♦s and also the ♣A then you will go down. It doesn't matter if he has the ♣Q because you can finesse him out of that.

But in the case where South has both the ♣ A Q you need to make sure he has no ♦ when he takes his first trick. So hold up the ♦A until the third round, everybody following.

North continues with the ♦Q; dummy plays the ♦5 and South the ♦9.

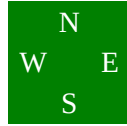
North continues with the ♦J; dummy plays the ♦7

Board 5

North Deals
N-S Vul

♠ K 7 5 3
♥ J 9
♦ J 8 5 2
♣ Q 10 4

♠ J 10 9 4
♥ K Q 2
♦ A K 9
♣ K 7 6



♠ 6
♥ A 10 8 6 4
♦ 10 7 3
♣ J 8 3 2

♠ A Q 8 2
♥ 7 5 3
♦ Q 6 4
♣ A 9 5

West	North	East	South
	1NT	Pass	3NT

All Pass
3NT by North
Lead: ♥6

it ride. West wins their third trick with the ♠K but has no ♥ to return so he plays a ♦ which you win with your ♦A.

Play off your 7 winners and give up a ♣ at the end.

The K Q x holding is similar to the A J x holding. It might be two stoppers, or might just be one, depending on which defender next leads the suit.

So you decide whether to hold up or not based on how you expect to play the hand.

With his 4-3-3-3 distribution South chooses not to bother with Stayman. North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♥6, dummy plays the ♥3 and West the ♥J.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=1 ♦=3 ♣=2 Total = 7

You need to get two more winners. The ♥ suit might provide one of them, but you will still have to establish ♠s. The burning question is whether to win the first ♥ or to hold up. If you take this trick you will have a second stopper if East takes the lead, but you will be in extreme danger if West takes the lead. Since the ♠ finesse has to go into West you should hold up.

West returns the ♥9, East takes the ♥A and clears the suit.

You have lost two tricks so far. Lead the ♠J and let it ride. West wins their third trick with the ♠K but has no ♥ to return so he plays a ♦ which you win with your ♦A.

Board 6

East Deals

E-W Vul

♠ J 10 9 4
♥ 7 5 3
♦ A K 9
♣ A 9 5

♠ 7 6 5

♥ J 9

♦ J 8 5 2

♣ Q 10 4 2

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ A Q 8 2

♥ K Q 2

♦ Q 6 4

♣ K 7 6

♠ K 3

♥ A 10 8 6 4

♦ 10 7 3

♣ J 8 3

West

North

East

South

1NT

Pass

3NT

All Pass

3NT by East

Lead: ♥6

With his 4-3-3-3 distribution West chooses not to bother with Stayman. East is to play 3NT. South leads the ♥6, dummy plays the ♥3 and North the ♥J.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=1 ♦=3 ♣=2 Total = 7

You need to get two more winners. The ♥ suit might provide one of them, but you will still have to establish ♠s. The burning question is whether to win the first ♥ or to hold up. If you take this trick you will have a second stopper if South takes the lead, but you will be in extreme danger if North takes the lead. Since the ♠ finesse has to go into South you should not hold up.

You win with your ♥K, (keeping South in the dark about who holds the ♥Q), enter dummy with the ♦A and play the ♠J, letting it ride to South's ♠K.

South cannot play ♥s without setting up your ♥Q so he will probably exit with a ♣ which you take with the ♣K.

Play off your 6 winners and concede the last three tricks.

This was almost the same as Deal 5, the difference being in which direction the ♠ finesse had to be taken.

But it sure makes a big difference in how you play the hand.

This might have turned out even better. If South had decided to play his partner for the ♥Q, (who would have played ♥J from a holding of ♥ Q J x), you would have made an overtrick!